

FREE RESOURCE · EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE

Empathy in the Workplace Guide

A practical guide to developing and applying empathy at work — perspective-taking, active listening, and empathic communication techniques.

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WHY THIS MATTERS AT WORK

Empathy is often treated as a personality trait some people simply have and others don't. In practice, it's closer to a set of specific, learnable skills — perspective-taking, listening, and communicating in a way that reflects genuine understanding. This guide breaks each of those down into something you can actually practise.

Empathy: Definition and Types

Empathy is the capacity to understand and share the feelings of another person, and to respond to that understanding appropriately. Psychologists commonly distinguish three related but distinct types.

TYPE OF EMPATHY

Cognitive Empathy

Understanding another person's perspective and reasoning intellectually, even without sharing their emotional state.

At work: A manager uses cognitive empathy to understand why a team member pushed back on a deadline, by genuinely considering their competing priorities before responding.

TYPE OF EMPATHY

Emotional Empathy

Actually resonating with what another person feels — a felt, visceral sense of their emotional state, not just an intellectual understanding of it.

At work: *Sensing the tension in a colleague's voice on a call before they've said anything is wrong is emotional empathy at work.*

TYPE OF EMPATHY

Compassionate Empathy

Understanding and feeling combined with being moved to actually help — empathy that leads to action, not just recognition.

At work: *Noticing a teammate is overwhelmed, understanding why, and then actually offering to take something off their plate is compassionate empathy.*

WHY THE DISTINCTION MATTERS

Strong cognitive empathy without compassionate empathy can produce someone who understands others perfectly but never acts on it. Strong emotional empathy without cognitive empathy can lead to absorbing others' distress without being able to help clearly. The most effective workplace empathy tends to draw on all three.

Perspective-Taking Techniques

Perspective-taking is the most trainable component of empathy — a deliberate practice, not a fixed trait.

- 1 Ask “what am I missing?”**
Assume there is context, pressure, or history you don't have visibility into — because there usually is.
- 2 Consider their constraints, not just their behaviour**
What deadlines, resources, or competing demands might explain a decision that looks unreasonable from the outside?
- 3 Reverse the roles explicitly**
Ask: “If I were them, in their exact position, how would I want to be treated right now?”
- 4 Separate intent from impact**
Assume good intent by default, and look at the situation in terms of what they were actually trying to achieve.
- 5 Mentally sit in their seat**
Picture the situation from their physical and organisational vantage point — their manager, their workload, their incentives — not just yours.

Active Listening Guide

Most people believe they listen well. Most people also interrupt, half-listen while planning their response, or reach for a solution before the other person has finished explaining the problem.

- 1 Give full attention**
Put the phone away and close the laptop — partial attention is often more noticeable, and more damaging, than no time at all.
- 2 Reflect back what you heard**
“What I’m hearing is…” before you respond confirms understanding and signals that you were actually listening, not just waiting to speak.
- 3 Ask open-ended follow-up questions**
“What happened next?” invites more than “Did that upset you?”, which can be answered in one word.
- 4 Notice what’s not being said**
Tone, pace, and body language often carry more signal than the words themselves — pay attention to all three.
- 5 Resist the urge to problem-solve immediately**
Sometimes people need to be heard before they need a solution; jumping to fixes too fast can feel like being dismissed.
- 6 Tolerate silence**
Don’t rush to fill every pause — people often need a few seconds to find the words for what they actually mean.

Empathic Communication Scripts

These are starting points, not scripts to recite word-for-word — adapt the language to sound like you, while keeping the underlying structure.

Someone is venting about a frustrating situation

“*That sounds really frustrating. Tell me more about what happened.*”

Validates the emotion first, before any problem-solving begins.

Delivering difficult feedback

“*I want to share something that might be hard to hear, because I think it matters for your growth.*”

Names the discomfort honestly and frames the feedback around their benefit, not just the correction itself.

Someone made a mistake

“*This clearly isn’t the outcome you wanted either. What do you need right now to fix it?*”

Assumes good intent and moves toward a solution together, rather than assigning blame first.

A colleague seems overwhelmed

“*You seem like you’re carrying a lot right now — what’s the biggest thing on your plate?*”

Names the observation directly and invites them to specify, rather than guessing on their behalf.

Disagreeing with someone's idea

“I see why that approach makes sense given the timeline you're working with. Here's a concern I have...”

Acknowledges their reasoning as valid before introducing a different view, rather than leading with the disagreement.

Someone is upset with you directly

“I hear that this affected you, and I want to understand fully before I respond.”

Slows the exchange down and prioritises understanding over immediate self-defence.

A NOTE ON AUTHENTICITY

These techniques and scripts only work when they reflect genuine curiosity about the other person — used mechanically, without real interest behind them, people tend to notice the difference. Treat this guide as a way to practise a capability you're building, not a formula to perform.